Bún sườn

This is a dish that my Mum would make us for breakfast (yes, we often have savoury breakfasts in Vietnam!), or even a weekend dinner. The broth is light yet flavourful, and the meat tender and falling off the bone. Needless to say, this for sure helps us to wake up in the morning!

4 servings 1 hour 15 mins

INGREDIENTS

For the broth

500 g pork ribs, cut into 2-inch cubes
300g pineapple
2 tomatoes, cut into wedges
½ onion, minced
1 tbsp fish sauce, and extra fish sauce to season to taste
2 tsps MSG (optional), 1 tsp sugar, salt to taste, sliced chili (optional)
2 L water

For the noodles

300 g dried rice vermicelli
1 L of water

For the side vegetables (optional)

¼ lettuce, thinly sliced
Fresh herbs, like coriander and blanched bean sprouts

Note: We Vietnamese love to pair our dishes with fresh herbs and vegetables. The side vegetables in this soup help to balance out the bold flavours and add a depth of texture and freshness to the dish!

DIRECTIONS

1. Prepare the broth: saute the onions with a dash of oil in a large pot until fragrant. Add half of the tomatoes and saute with fish sauce. When the tomato softens, add the pork ribs and saute until the pork ribs firm up slightly. Add water, pineapple, sugar, and leave to simmer for at least 1 hour, or until the meat is fall-off-the-bone tender.
2. Boil the rice vermicelli according to package instructions. Drain and set aside.
3. Prepare the side vegetables: slice lettuce and arrange fresh herbs and bean sprouts.
4. After about 1 hour of cooking, check on the broth. Season with fish sauce and/or salt to taste.
5. Divide the noodles into bowls, and warm them up warm them up (microwave for about 30 seconds, if needed). Ladle on the soup, and enjoy it with the fresh vegetables!

Hi, it's Nguyen. In case you have any questions about the recipe, feel free to reach out to me at nguyenhnguyen09@gmail.com. Enjoy!

Thịt kho tàu

This is one of my favourite dishes to make as a student studying abroad. The ingredients are simple and easy to find, and the dish itself is comforting and tastes like home.

4 servings 1 hour 15 mins

INGREDIENTS

500 g pork belly or pork shoulder
4 eggs, medium size
½ tbsp sugar to make the caramel
¼ onion, finely chopped
500 ml coconut water
1 tbsp fish sauce

Note: Personally, I like the eggs to be a bit jammy in the middle, after cooking in the sauce. This is how I achieve it: put the eggs in a pot with cold water, and bring to a boil. Once boiling, add a pinch of salt to the pot (this makes it a lot easier to peel!) and boil on for exactly 6 more minutes. Immediately transfer to a cold water bath to stop the cooking process.

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DIRECTIONS

1. Cut the meat into cubes of around 1-inch length. Marinate with 1 tsp fish sauce and the chopped onions.
2. Make the caramel: Heat ½ tbsp sugar in a medium-size pot, at medium heat. When the sugar starts to melt, reduce the heat to medium-low, and stir gently. When the sugar changes to a brownish colour, remove from the heat and add 1–2 tbsp of water (be careful as it may splatter). Stir to dissolve the sugar. Transfer the liquid to a bowl and set aside.

3. Add the pot back on the heat, and add the meat. Add 1tbsp of fish sauce and sauté until the meat firms up (about 5 minutes). Add 500 ml of coconut water and the liquid caramel and bring to a boil. You can also add a chilli at this stage to the stew! Once boiling, reduce the heat to medium-low, cover, and leave to simmer for around 1 hour, or until the meat is tender.
4. Boil the eggs, peel, and set aside.
5. Once the meat is tender, add the eggs and cook for around 10 minutes, or until the eggs are coated in the sauce and have a beautiful golden brown colour.
6. Transfer to a serving dish, sprinkle on some black pepper, and enjoy with rice!

Gỏi cuốn

This was one of my favourite 'special' dinners growing up. We would gather the vegetables, make the sauce, and roll our own cuốn, while enjoying them. My Dad was the only one who did not enjoy the rolling process. He would get too impatient and end up mixing all the ingredients in one bowl!

4 servings 45 minutes

INGREDIENTS

For the cuốn

300 g pork belly or pork shoulder
16 large shrimps, peeled and deveined
200g dry rice vermicelli
¼ pineapple
1 cucumber
1 carrot
100g lettuce
Rice paper, at least 15 sheets
Fresh herbs (optional)

For the sauce

10 tbsps water
1 tbsps sugar
2 tbsps fish sauce
2 tbsps lime juice
1 tsp minced garlic
Sliced chili (optional)

DIRECTIONS

1. Boil the rice vermicelli according to package instructions. Drain and set aside.
2. Boil the pork for around 15 - 20 minutes, or until the water runs clear. Transfer to a dish and set aside to cool.
3. Boil the shrimps. Transfer to a dish and set aside to cool.
4. Cut the meat and veggies into thin slices. Cut the shrimps in half along the back.

5. Make the sauce: Simmer water and sugar gently until dissolved. Turn off the heat and stir in fish sauce, lime juice, garlic, and chilli (if using). Divide the sauce into 4 small bowls for dipping.
6. Making the cuốn: Wet the rice paper and set on a large plate. Add a slice of lettuce, then some fresh herbs, a few slices of carrots and cucumbers, then a bit of vermicelli and a slice of pork. Roll halfway, fold in the sides. Add two slices of shrimp and finish rolling.
7. Dip into the sauce and enjoy!

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